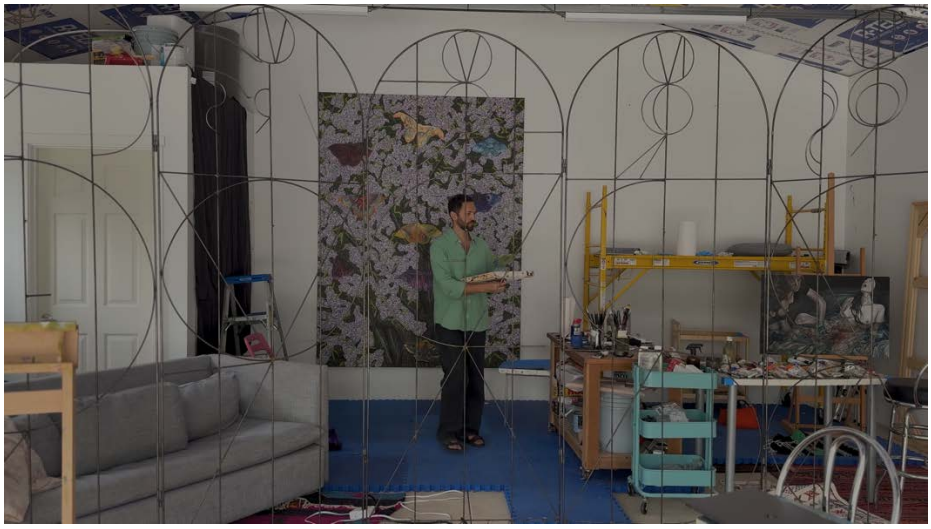
P·P·O·W

Art Basel

My Portland: artist Srijon Chowdhury

Art Basel, August 19, 2026

From nature preserves to tarot-inspired canvases, the painter shares his anchor points across the Pacific Northwest city ahead of the 2026 Converge 45 Triennale



What is your first memory of Portland?

I came to visit my girlfriend, now my wife, in 2013, when I was living in LA. The first thing I noticed was how good it smelled. She took me to the waterfalls outside of town, and I could not believe how green it was: plants growing on plants growing on trees growing on cliff edges. So much life, so much air.

Why did you choose Portland as your home?

I could see having a really beautiful life here.

What is the mark of a true Portlander?

Loving the rain. Which I do not. I love everything it grows, but I complain about the grey, and I am often met with surprise by people who genuinely love it.

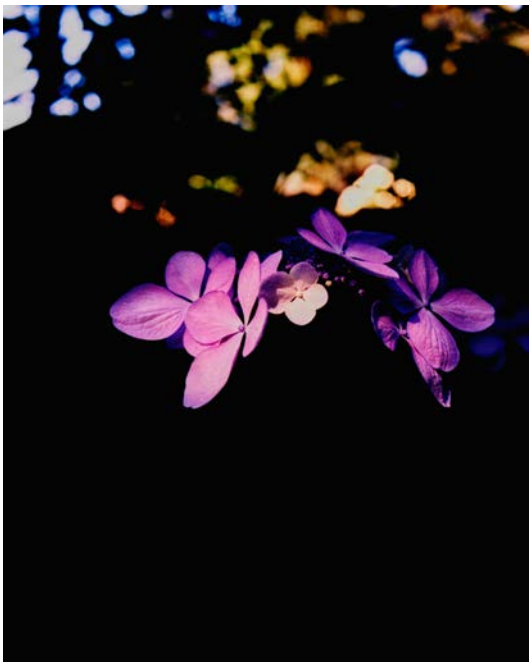
How does the city inspire you?

My studio runs down to a creek and a protected wildlife area, and deer are always in the yard eating from my apple trees. At the bottom of my hill is Leach Botanical Garden, where I used to be the maintenance man. This is a city that gives you access to incredible nature.

Which one of your works or series is most connected to your life in the city?

I have been making paintings of the cherry tree in my backyard. Ten days a year it explodes into pink and white 30 feet in the air, and those 10 days are my anchor to this city. I am painting five canopies of it, 30 feet wide together, for P·P·O·W next year, each with a different diagram of esoteric knowledge hovering above the blooms.





What does it mean for you to show your work at the 2026 Converge 45 Triennale?

It is an honor, and a good excuse to get out of my little corner of Portland. The show includes 22 small paintings of the Fool from the tarot. In Chittagong, Bangladesh where my father's family is from, *phool* means flower, so ‘the fool’ and ‘the flower’ have always been the same word to me. I am excited to show my foolish explorations of the tarot in my city.

What are you most looking forward to seeing at the Triennale?

Sidony O'Neal and Keyon Gaskin at Barn Radio.

A performance by Keyon at Yale Union, which no longer exists, was the first and possibly greatest art I saw in Portland: Keyon approached every audience member, asked when they were last scared, applied black lipstick, and asked if they could kiss the person and where, then stripped nude, climbed the beams, climbed back down, and tap-danced out of there.



Which artwork best represents Portland?

I want to say that piece by Keyon, but also Leach Botanical Garden, started by the botanist Lilla Leach and her husband. They built a stone cabin, traveled Oregon with pack burros collecting plant specimens, and built a beautiful life devoted to nature.

Which Portland neighborhood should visitors stay in to feel like a local?

Mt. Tabor. Get a coffee and a chocolate chip cookie at Coquine, then walk to the top of Mt. Tabor Park and look at the whole city.

What is the craziest thing you have seen or heard in Portland?

It is pretty crazy seeing people openly smoking fentanyl downtown. But something a little more unique is that during COVID-19 lockdowns, I would take my kids on long drives for their naps. One day I was on the outskirts of Portland, just weaving through rural neighborhoods, and when I got to the end of this very normal road, there was standing this huge sculpture of Anubis, beyond a massive stone arched gateway.

What do you miss most when you are far away?

My kids.





What is your best advice for visitors?

Come in the spring to see the cherry blossoms along the waterfront. Drive the Historic Columbia River Highway and stop at every waterfall. Go to all the gardens. Get a Bryan's Bowl at ¿Por Qué No?

Credits and captions

Srijon Chowdhury lives and works in Portland, Oregon. His work will be presented as part of the 2026 edition of *Converge 45 Triennale,* open across various venues on August 27, 2026 in Portland.

Srijon Chowdhury is represented by P·P·O·W (New York). All photographs and videos by Daniel Fickle for Art Basel.

P·P·O·W

Arte Realizzata
9 Must-See Works at Art Basel Miami Beach

uzomah ugwu, December 11, 2025



Seven Sunflowers and the Sun, 2025, oil on linen 48 x 72 ins. 121.9 x 182.9 cm

As the international art calendar draws to a close, Art Basel Miami Beach once again asserts itself as the definitive anchor event of the year — a vital convergence point where artistic, commercial, and curatorial currents from across the Americas meet in concentrated dialogue. Far more than a seasonal spectacle, the fair functions as a barometer for the present moment, revealing how artists and galleries are responding to shifting social, political, and material conditions with renewed urgency, nuance, and imagination.

What distinguishes Art Basel Miami Beach is not only its scale, but its carefully articulated structure. Through sectors such as Meridians, Nova, Statements, and Galleries, the fair facilitates a layered engagement with contemporary practice — one that moves seamlessly from monumental ambition to intimate material inquiry. These divisions encourage a slower, more considered navigation of the fairground, prompting visitors to encounter artworks not as isolated commodities, but as part of broader conversations around form, labor, historiography, identity, and collective memory.

This year's presentation is marked by an especially compelling cross-section of voices, spanning intergenerational practices, global geographies, and rigorously diverse material languages — from hand-blown mirrored environments and bead-based tapestries to immersive figurative painting and feminist reconfigurations of the body. In response, we have assembled a curated selection of seven standout works that exemplify the intellectual and aesthetic breadth of the fair. Each offers a distinctive entry point into the pressing questions animating contemporary art today, and together they provide a revealing lens through which to experience Art Basel Miami Beach at its most resonant.

Srijon Chowdhury's *Seven Sunflowers and the Sun* (2025) at P·P·O·W

Srijon Chowdhury's richly saturated paintings occupy a liminal terrain between the personal and the mythological, merging quotidian imagery with metaphysical symbolism. His compositions, often dense and dreamlike, stage surreal ecosystems where bodies, flora, and spectral presences coexist in hallucinatory

proximity. Drawing from ecological, theological, and philosophical frameworks, Chowdhury constructs immersive visual worlds that hover between narrative and abstraction.

Through his hyper-detailed technique, Chowdhury transforms intimacy into monument — collapsing the ordinary into the uncanny. The work's visual rhythm oscillates between spellbinding beauty and quiet unease, capturing cycles of growth, decay, and transcendence. In doing so, his practice articulates a deeply contemporary longing: to reconcile the sacred and the mundane in a fractured world.

P·P·O·W

ELEPHANT

“The Question is the Most Important Thing”: The Art World’s Tarot for the Month Ahead

Vittoria Benzine, November 20, 2025

Vittoria Benzine, *Elephant’s* resident psychic, returns to read the art world’s tarot. What came true from her last reading? What new revelations do the cards hold for the industry’s ever-elusive psyche?



Installation view of Spotlight: Srijon Chowdhury at The FLAG Art Foundation, 2025. Photo by Steven Probert.

There’s a fun, altar-heavy magic show up at New York’s FLAG Art Foundation through January. Srijon Chowdhury just debuted *Cycled Through the Wildflower Arcana* (2025) amidst this exhibition, on the Foundation’s Spotlight wall. The Portland-based artist produced this painting while making his latest show at Ciaccia Levi gallery. It’s the first time he’s put tarot in his art, which typically depicts nature, divinity, and motherhood—even though he’s been using cards since 2018. The work started when a mantra got stuck in his head years ago: “Life is so easy, life is so hard.”

The twenty-two panels in *Wildflower Arcana* correspond to the twenty-two cards of the tarot’s major arcana. This isn’t a linear traipse through the Fool’s Journey, however. The cards are scrambled—you can read them along the x-, y-, or z-axis. Critic Doreen St. Felix provided stirring context as part of the work’s debut. I asked Chowdhury whether he considers tarot a vessel for spirits or a framework for the subconscious. To him, every card’s a spirit, and “the question is the most important thing.”

So true. When I started giving readings, I’d often ask querents how they thought we should lay the cards out. No one knew, and some didn’t even know what to ask. They all wanted to be guided.

Assuredness is necessary in tarot. Or is it? Either way, it’s a skill I’ve had to learn, as I was reminded again at a recent symposium related to Liu Yang’s show at the private museum Amant, in Brooklyn. There, the brothers behind the virtual performance studio Team Rolfes noted that guests at their live show often need someone to tell them when to sit, dance, and laugh.

Inspired by Chowdhury's remark, I ask my tarot cards what questions the art world should be asking. I let a new spread come to me, too. The shape dawns on me first: a ten-card pyramid. The sensation of two harpies on either side crops up, so I pull two tiny Rider-Waite cards to elucidate what questions we should ignore. Another, up top, serves as the spread's lodestar.



Our tarot spread asks what questions the art world should be asking. Photo by Vittoria Benzine.

I shuffle in my dark, quiet room, heeding my inner voice's call to pull the pyramid top-down. Eyes closed, I pick up the mini Rider-Waites and instinctively pull those bottoms up. Cards are such a cool medium—every step matters. The choice to flip the decks over and put them beneath the pyramid also arises right on my yoga mat. I flick the lights and let the cards speak.

The World is perched atop the pyramid. This card is noteworthy—it's the major arcana's grand finale—and emphasised by the Ten of Pentacles above it. It seems we should be asking about sustainable, shareable abundance. The two distracting voices—the devils on both shoulders, if you will—are the Emperor and the Four of Cups. These are structure and boredom, respectively.

Three key features jump out at me. First, the Seven of Cups reversed (our old friend!) came out touching the Eight of Cups reversed one step down. Next to that lies a striking trio of pentacle cards: the Seven of Pentacles (right by the Seven of Cups, mind you) atop the Three and Five of Pentacles (which makes eight, by the way). I usually wouldn't go so far as to sum the Three and Five together into another in this way, but look at them—they're so clearly related! There's a repeating pattern here: seven to eight, seven to eight, descending both times.

This line of questioning intensifies when I notice the Nine of Swords below the Three and Five of Pentacles—and the Rider-Waite's High Priestess to its right. These two cards are the King and Queen of overthinking. Then, as I move the decks to photograph this spread—sorry, you're not seeing my yoga mat—I spot Justice just beneath them both. Now there's a sign. It all evens out.

What about the other half of this spread? Honestly, it's abject chaos: the Four of Wands reversed, The Devil, the King of Swords reversed. These are our most basic, animal instincts.

Much like *Wildflower Arcana* has its own logic, an ad hoc spread like this reveals its own rules. When read in terms of the ten at the top, the seven-eight-nine progression we just discussed on the other side betrays a zero-gravity state. Does this mean ascension is all about letting go? By that reasoning, the right side culminates in the moon. Art world, have you been lying to yourself?



Detail of *Cycled Through the Wildflower Arcana*, illustrating the many ways you can read the painting—a parallel to our spread. Photo by Steven Probert.

The other side of the spread looks great by comparison. In fact, it's a pretty clear split. Structure seems to be the way. We need to be asking how to set up systems that'll maximise happiness.

Maybe we'll explore that matter further in next month's year-end reading. In the meantime, here's an apt question from a reader: what kind of work should be made right now to heal the collective? A spread for this inquiry emerged immediately as four cards filled in the blanks. The result: we need art that is celebratory but not comfortable for a world weary with a work ethic.

And last but not least, here's what we all want to know: what's going to happen this month? The Seven of Pentacles reversed, with the Ten of Cups and Judgement. It seems like the art world has a fun holiday season ahead—though not a frivolous one. The Judgement is an awakening.



Our impromptu spread answering what the art world needs right now. Photo by Vittoria Benzine.

P·P·O·W

artnet

The Best Art of 2024: 11 Standouts We Saw Globally

Katie White, December 29, 2024

From blockbuster shows to hidden gems, here's what caught our eye.



Srijon Chowdhury, *Eye (Birth)* (2022). Courtesy of the artist and P·P·O·W

As 2024 comes to a close, the Artnet News team has taken a moment to reflect on the year in art. From gallery shows and museum exhibitions to biennials and art fairs, we've seen it all.

Amid the whirlwind of creativity, some works stood out—whether for their extraordinary craftsmanship, profound meaning, or undeniable artistic virtuosity. Here's what captured our attention—and our hearts—in 2024.

Srijon Chowdhury, *Eye (Birth)* (2022). Courtesy of the artist and P·P·O·W

Earlier this fall, while rushing to an interview, I was stopped in my tracks by a painting hanging in P·P·O·W's storefront window on Broadway. The painting, titled *Eye (Birth)* (2022), and by artist Srijon Chowdhury, is a visceral, momentous depiction of childbirth. A mother appears, naked in a birthing, her face in ecstatic pain as the baby emerges. Two figures, a midwife, and perhaps the father, flank her like saints or angels.

This sublimely intense scene, meanwhile, is painted, tondo-like, in the iris of a massive eye, which occupies the rest of the canvas. This push and pull of scale and place, viewer, and subject, somehow capturing the out-of-body experience of witnessing new life. Chowdhury, who is based in Portland, Oregon, paints with

sinewy, prismatic gestures and in saturated jewel tones that his paintings often take on this metaphysical beauty.

Eye (Birth) was on view at P·P·O·W in “Tapestry” the Bangladeshi-American artist’s debut with the gallery, earlier this fall, and it a remarkable exhibition of painting and sculptures, weaving together moments from the artist’s life, philosophy, religion, plant life, architecture and art history. Chowdhury has a way for conveying both the bloody and beautiful parts of life with a magical potency that I felt at times like I was walking within the pages of an illuminated manuscript.

P·P·O·W

ART SY

5 Artists on Our Radar in October 2024

Olivia Horn, October 1, 2024

“Artists on Our Radar” is a monthly series focused on five artists who have our attention. Utilizing our art expertise and Artsy data, we’ve determined which artists made an impact this past month through new gallery representation, exhibitions, auctions, art fairs, or fresh works on Artsy.



Srijon Chowdhury, *Eye (Birth),* 2022, P·P·O·W

Srijon Chowdhury
B. 1987, Dhaka, Bangladesh. Lives and works in Portland, Oregon.

A giant, gaping mouth is the anchor of “Tapestry,” Srijon Chowdhury’s debut solo exhibition with New York gallery P·P·O·W. Painted across five linen panels that together take up some 30 feet of wall space, its meaty, sprawling lips open onto a scarlet inferno filled with cavorting skeletal figures. The monumental work, *Mouth (Divine Dance)* (2022), elicits fear in multiple forms: of damnation, yes, but also the day-to-day horrors of being alive in a human body.

Chowdhury’s paintings are striking and dense, laden with references to art history and the artist’s own past work. He frequently paints the body, rendering skin in sinewy swirls. These images are sometimes visceral but also harness moments of tenderness, rest, and natural wonder. For instance, one memorable work in “Tapestry” features an inflamed eye in which the iris is replaced by a tondo of childbirth. In short, the paintings reflect the messy breadth of human experience.

An MFA graduate of the Otis College of Art and Design in Los Angeles, Chowdhury has been the subject of solo exhibitions at the Frye Art Museum in Seattle, Foxy Production in New York, Anat Ebgi in Los Angeles, and others. He is represented by P·P·O·W,and runs the exhibition space Chicken Coop Contemporary in Portland, Oregon.

P·P·O·W

PLUS

Srijon Chowdhury: Boundaries of Perception

Plus Magazine, September 17, 2024



Portrait of Srijon Chowdhury in his studio, 2024. Aaron Wessling Photography.

Srijon Chowdhury's work occupies a liminal space between reality and dream, where meticulous realism intertwines with surreal, exaggerated forms. Drawing inspiration from Andrew Wyeth's mystic depictions of America, Chowdhury delves into the minute details of light and shadow, transforming the ordinary into something transcendent. His approach to painting, rooted in sensory perception and the materiality of paint, invites viewers to engage with his work viscerally. In his latest exhibition *Tapestry* at P·P·O·W, Chowdhury's symbolic use of circular structures and welded steel fencing further blurs the lines between the physical and the metaphysical.

PLUS: Your work often oscillates between the realms of uncanny realism and highly stylized compositions. How do you navigate these contrasting approaches in your practice, and what do they reveal about your perception of reality?

SRIJON CHOWDHURY: I have to be excited by what Im painting. I love Andrew Wyeth and I think the desire to try for a realist aspect of my current paintings owes a lot to him. Wyeth captures a feeling of American mysticism that is hard for me to put into words. When I focus and paint "reality," I tend to get lost in the details of lights and shadows on veins and skin, and I can't help but exaggerate these strange lines that I see. When I was in college, I drew caricatures at a theme park and have always loved exaggeration. It looks stylized, but the lines and shapes are mostly what was there. I've been holding leaves up to the sun; there is so much to see, it's unbelievably real. The other day my four-year-old son asked me if this was a dream or real life, I rattled off a bunch of possibilities until he said he was ready to be done talking about that now. I like falling into hallucinogenic thinking, but then you have to get back to beautiful reality.

P: Your work often immerses viewers in a sensory experience, particularly through the interplay of light, color, and texture. How do you approach the materiality of your paintings to evoke such a visceral response, and what role does sensory perception play in your artistic narrative?



Srijon Chowdhury. Justin at Latourell Falls, 2024 oil on linen. 48 x 96 ins. 121.9 x 243.8 cm. Courtesy of Srijon Chowdhury and P·P·O·W, New York.

SC: A painting always needs to be about the paint. It has to do something only a painting can do, something words can't express. I have fallen into using a very small range of colors in the past, trying to understand what they do and how they make me feel. I am so interested in how colors and their combinations can make us feel. I've been painting for 20 years, but I am very much at the beginning of learning what paint can do.

P: In your exhibition *Tapestry* at P·P·O·W, the welded steel circular fence serves as both a physical structure and a symbolic enclosure. Can you discuss the significance of this structure within the context of your larger body of work and its relationship to William Blake's poetry?

SC: A terracotta mosque built by my great-great-grandfather on the coast of Bangladesh has been a driving inspiration for about 10 years. I've been making circular structures trying to mimic the mosque. Just as I want to see how paint and color act on a person, I'm interested to see how a structure with belief embedded in it acts on a person. My structure takes 2 poems by William Blake, one about the lighter aspects of being human, the other the dark aspects, and turns them loosely into sigils, an old form of magic. I wanted to think about balance and interconnectedness, which I think is heightened by hanging works on the structure, seeing through it to other people looking at other works.

P: What does this spatial dialogue contribute to the overall experience of your work?

SC: The viewer, I believe, gets a heightened awareness of their own body in the space in front of and within the paintings, which I feel must heighten the feeling experienced. It's an experiment; I want to learn from this show.

P: Your exhibition also features *Mouth*, a monumental painting measuring 30 feet across that illustrates subjects and motifs from your previous works. Can you share more about this composition and the different imagery appearing throughout the work?



Srijon Chowdhury. Dean Dreaming, 2024. oil on linen. 30 x 40 ins. 76.2 x 101.6 cm. Courtesy of Srijon Chowdhury and P·P·O·W, New York.

SC: *Mouth* is a retrospective I gave myself, there are over 100 of my paintings from the last 10 years revisited in the creases of the lips. Portraits of my friends and family, flowers, monuments, angels, etc. Inside the mouth are figures happily dancing in red flames. When I first had the idea I was thinking of the flame dancers as a sort of apocalyptic climate anxiety fever. But now I am more comfortable with the apocalypse; it's the beginning, and I am beginning to sense that the apocalypse has already happened, and I just didn't notice.

P: Some of your works are more autobiographical in nature, including paintings of your wife giving birth to your children, and also appearances from friends and loved ones. Can you describe how these connect to your life and whether these should be read as a diary or narrative of sorts about your life?

SC: The easiest thing for me to paint is my life. I read too much meaning into things. Everyday moments gift me images that I think about for days or years until they eventually crystallize into a painting. And then I often come back to images as their meaning for me changes, and I need to make a new painting of an old image. My favorite movie is Groundhog Day; as a kid, I thought it was fun. When I was 20, I realized he had been trapped there for thousands of years and was essentially a god; it was almost a horror (maybe it would be a perfect double feature with Hellraiser?), right now I see that, yes, he was trapped but he also made a beautiful and meaningful life for himself. These paintings are people I know and have seen change, moments I see, but also moments I force into being; it's a diary, a fiction, a poem more than a narrative.

P: Your use of floral imagery, particularly the cherry tree in *Tapestry*, appears to evoke a sense of fleeting beauty and cyclical life. How do these botanical motifs resonate with the themes of temporality and transcendence in your work?

SC: I love flowers. I used to work at Leach Botanical Garden, which is a quick walk down the hill from my house. The anticipation of certain things popping up and blooming slows down the year. In my own garden, some years can be better than others. Every year is a chance to get a little better, a little closer to my dream of having a garden that looks like a Bonnard painting.

P: Can you talk more about the references behind these works?

SC: Most of the tiny flowers are from the unicorn tapestries at the Met Cloisters and Musee de Cluny. I love painting and borrow so much: Frida Kahlo, Remedios Varo, Leonora Carrington, Andrew Wyeth, Otto Dix, Odilon Redon, Georgia O'Keefe, Klimt, Gustave Moreau, Lucian Freud, etc… If I see something I like, it will eventually end up in a painting.

P: Reflecting on your journey as an artist, is there a particular moment or experience that you consider pivotal in shaping your artistic vision?

SC: When I was 21, I read 2666 by Roberto Bolano. It's a novel made up of five novellas. It's sort of a mystery. By the end, I felt I had read everything except the actual story and that the empty space that was left, that I had read around and danced around, could be filled with the whole world. I have wanted to make paintings like that ever since.

P·P·O·W

FRIEZE

5 Exhibitions to Visit During The Armory Show

Jesse Dorris, September 6, 2024

From Srijon Chowdhury's spectacular debut at P·P·O·W, to a tightly edited show of Mark Armijo McKnight's work at the Whitney Museum of American Art, here's what not to miss in New York City.

'Srijon Chowdhury: Tapestry' | P·P·O·W | 6 September – 19 October



Srijon Chowdhury, *Eye (Birth),* 2022, oil on linen, 2 × 3 m. Courtesy: Srijon Chowdhury and P·P·O·W, New York

Srijon Chowdhury's debut at P·P·O·W just might be the most spectacular show of paintings in a very crowded season. The exhibition assembles a nervy collection of oil-on-linen work which manages to synthesize pre-Raphaelite nature worship, Islamic and Buddhist architecture, the gothic shiver-thrills of Hieronymus Bosch and William Blake, and the last 400 years of innovation in oil-painting techniques. Chowdhury seems to be able to do almost anything, and here he does everything, from pointillist fields of flowers that shimmer with LSD intensity to long strokes that ripple like plumes of air. His painted bodies are astonishing, rendered with an adoration that honours our anatomy without syphoning off all the strangeness. This isn't so much body horror as body wonder. A bravura five-panel piece, *Mouth (Divine Dance)* (2022), dominates the space, with lips (themselves formed from figures in previous work) parting like portals into a red, wet mouth of raving devil figures, their potential kitsch annihilated by the infectious joy of their dance. Seeing is believing.

P·P·O·W

FAD

P·P·O·W now represent Srijon Chowdhury

Mark Westall, August 28, 2024

P·P·O·W has announced the representation of the artist Srijon Chowdhury and will open his first solo exhibition *Tapestry* next week.



Oscillating between a highly stylized technique and uncanny realism, the Portland-based artist's prismatic compositions elements from daily life to find the universal in the quotidian. Combining interests in philosophy, religion, ecology, and art history, Chowdhury's intensely detailed, saturated, and hypnotic narrative compositions transform the artist's immediate environment into immersive dreamscapes where the boundaries between our physical reality and the metaphysical, mythological and the supernatural dissolve.

Speaking to subjective perceptual experience, Tapestry aims to transport the viewer on a visceral and emotional level. At the center of the gallery stands a welded steel circular fence. Developed over a decade, the structure mimics the architecture of a circular mosque built by the artist's ancestors in the coastal farmland of Bangladesh. In Chowdhury's construction, Islamic geometric patterning is replaced with the language of archaic sigils. The two halves of the sigil fence represent two poems by William Blake; "A Divine Image" and "The Divine Image." Counterparts, the poems contemplate the dark and light aspects of humanity. Affixed to the fence is a series of intimately scaled twists on traditional genre painting. Potently charged and framed by the fence's mysterious latticing, the paintings become the windows of an encloser which is both isolated from and inseparably connected to its exterior world. Referencing other structures such as Giulio Camillo's 16thcentury Theatre of Memory and Buddhist prayer wheels, Chowdhury's fence

is meant to be walked through, and activated by the viewers' sensory experience of image, symbol, and architecture. Surrounding the fence are several immersive large-scale paintings, which act as both backdrop and landscape for the circular structure. First exhibited in Same Old Song, Chowdhury's 2022 solo exhibition at the Frye Museum in Seattle, Mouth (Divine Dance), 2022, is a monumentally scaled painting comprising five panels which depict a fiery inferno framed by parted lips. Shadow-like figures clasp hands and dance amidst the flames, as if the whole of humanity has joined together in their shared fate. Chowdhury also faintly renders more than a hundred motifs and figures from his prior works along the wide mouth's lip creases, operating as a survey of the artists' rich symbolic lexicon.



Srijon Chowdhury Eye (Birth), 2022 oil on linen 72 x 114 ins. 182.9 x 289.6 cm, Courtesy of Srijon Chowdhury and P·P·O·W, New York



Srijon Chowdhury, Andreas with Wildflowers, 2024 oil on linen 72 x 60 ins. 182.9 x 152.4 cm, Courtesy of Srijon Chowdhury and P·P·O·W, New York

In many of Chowdhury's paintings, portraits of his family and natural surroundings can be viewed as both direct representations and greater universal archetypes. His engulfing floral patterns recall medieval allegories such as the unicorn tapestries which contemplate the dualistic nature of desire and love. In Tapestry, Chowdhury includes multiple depictions of a cherry tree that blooms once a year for one week in his backyard. Works such as Andreas with Wildflowers, 2024, depict the artist's friend leaning against the blossoming tree. However, instead of a domestic landscape, a riotous sea of wildflowers and sprawling tree limbs create a sublime architecture, punctuated by an abstract "rose window" at top of the canvas.



Srijon Chowdhury Mother & Son, 2024 oil on linen 48 x 36 ins. 121.9 x 91.4 cm, Courtesy of Srijon Chowdhury and P·P·O·W, New York

P·P·O·W

Arte Realizzata

Srijon Chowdhury Explores Mystical Realities in New Exhibition

Arte Realizatta, August 15, 2024



Srijon Chowdhury in his studio Photo: Aaron Wessling
Photography Courtesy of Srijon Chowdhury and P·P·O·W, New York

In a notable collaboration, P·P·O·W Gallery and Ciaccia Levi of Paris have joined forces to represent Portland-based artist Srijon Chowdhury, with his debut solo exhibition at P·P·O·W, *Tapestry*, set to open on September 6. Chowdhury's work, known for its vivid blend of realism and surrealism, draws deeply from his philosophical and religious explorations, crafting scenes that transcend the ordinary.

At the core of the exhibition is a circular steel installation, inspired by a mosque built by the artist's ancestors in Bangladesh. This striking structure, adorned with symbolic sigils that reinterpret Islamic geometric patterns, serves as a visual and emotional anchor, inviting visitors to engage with the dualities of human nature. Surrounding it are large-scale paintings, including the fiery *Mouth (Divine Dance),* which reflects Chowdhury's fascination with themes of fate and human connection.

Chowdhury's art often features personal elements, such as portraits of family members and natural settings, but these are elevated to explore broader, universal themes like the transient nature of life. Through *Tapestry*, he presents a powerful meditation on how art can capture beauty and meaning even in times of global upheaval.

Critic SJ Cowan describes Chowdhury's work as a manifestation of the "miracle of existence," urging viewers to experience the profound connection between art and the human condition.



Srijon Chowdhury Andreas with Wildflowers, 2024, oil on linen 72 x 60 ins.
182.9 x 152.4 cm Courtesy of Srijon Chowdhury and P·P·O·W, New York

P·P·O·W

Galerie

9 Artists to Watch from Future Fair, Independent, and NADA New York 2023

Paul Laster, May 24, 2023

Taking a deep dive into New York's two weeks of art fairs, *Galerie* looked for a select group of artists who should be on every collector's radar. Picking three emerging artists from each of the three fairs—Future Fair, Independent and NADA New York—offering younger painters and sculptors or artists who have been active but are finally getting their big breaks, we rounded up a curated mix of talents to add to your ones to watch list this season.



Srijon Chowdhury, *Eye*, (2023).PHOTO: COURTESY CIACCIA LEVI COURTESY AND FOXY PRODUCTION

5. Srijon Chowdhury at Ciaccia Levi and Foxy Production at Independent

A figurative painter who was born in Bangladesh and currently lives and works in Portland, Oregon, Srijon Chowdhury captures everyday scenes from his life and times using a symbolic style of painting. Expressing profound emotions and secretive states of mind, he paints poetic pictures that are equally personal and visceral—combining realism and symbolism while applying a mythical edge to domestic stories. For his solo show at the shared booth of Ciaccia Levi and Foxy Production, Chowdhury presented two large canvases of allegorical subjects inspired by Medieval manuscripts and a series of small paintings of bodies in moments of rawness and introspection—including the 2023 canvas *Eye*, which captures his hands holding a cellphone with an image of his wife reflected in his eye—attached to a fascinating arched steel fence that incorporates text from a William Blake poem.

P·P·O·W

Art in America

Getting Inside Srijon Chowdhury's Head

Bean Gilsdorg, October 7, 2022



Srijon Chowdhury: *Eye (Morning Glory)*, 2022; oil on linen, 6 by 10½ feet. COURTESY SRIJON CHOWDHURY

When Portland painter Srijon Chowdhury was invited to present a solo exhibition at the Frye Art Museum in Seattle, he asked himself, "what's the best kind of museum show an artist could have?" His answer: "a retrospective." Endeavoring to create the effect of a career survey with his first-ever museum exhibition, he produced a series of new mural-size paintings on panel incorporating much of the imagery that has appeared in his work over the last decade.

The Frye show, titled "Same Old Song," does not include any of his older paintings, but rather glimpses of past works in the form of motifs—things like morning glories, devils, angels, and knives. In creating the exhibition, the Bangladesh-born artist came to see these painted quotations as a kind of self-portraiture, so he literalized the concept: six of the works highlight his own facial features, all at enormous scale and in extreme close-up. "It turns the exhibition space into the inside of my head," he told me during a studio visit.

Each of these six studies has one gigantic feature that, on closer inspection, abounds with allusions to Chowdhury's symbolic vocabulary. Measuring a towering 10-and-a-half by 6 feet each, the five adjoined oil-on-linen panels that comprise *Mouth (Divine Dance)*, 2022, induce a sense of envelopment. The interior of the mouth is a hellscape, with flayed and skeletal figures dancing around a fire, imagery reprised from a work Chowdhury painted as a hex against Donald Trump during the 2020 election. Surrounding the mouth, in the creases of the lips, about 150 figures from Chowdhury's prior works are faintly rendered, like petroglyphs marking earlier civilizations.

The tension between epiphany and mystery remain an inspiration to Chowdhury. His 2017 exhibition "Revelation Theater" at the Art Gym at Marylhurst University in Oregon evoked the Book of Revelations, a

Biblical series of visions representing the tribulations and final judgments that await saint and sinner alike. For “Memory Theater” in 2016, a show at Upfor Gallery in Portland, Chowdhury reimagined 16th-century philosopher Giulio Camillo’s proposed architectural structure, whose physical reminders of all the world’s important concepts promised the viewer omniscience. These ideas of sacred vision and prognostication appear again in the 2022 works in the form of divine messengers delivering succor and retribution. “I’m always going back to something,” he said. “I wanted to have ‘Revelation Theater’ and ‘Memory Theater’ in this show.”

Other panels depict some of the recurring motifs in Chowdhury’s illustrative oeuvre, including the morning glory and knife that replace the pupil and iris of *Eye (Morning Glory)*, 2022. Both objects appear in multiple paintings made between 2018 and 2021—works that, for Chowdhury, allude to the thin veil that divides the everyday from the unknown.

The artist’s characteristic gestures include numerous art historical influences. The shell of the right ear in *Ear (Good)*, 2022, holds a Blakean angel slaying a shadowy, semitransparent devil bearing a Francis-Bacon-style melted face. These references link Chowdhury to artists who have grappled with beauty and terror, exploring their moral expressions by producing works that are anchored to the real yet expand into the surreal. He sees these allegorical representations as a way to respond to contemporary circumstances: “In a moment when everything constantly seems awful everywhere in the world, I feel like the worst thing I can do is stop caring,” adding, “the modern world began with the symbol, and now we’re at the end of modernity. Symbolism is a good way to bookend that time.”

P·P·O·W

ARTFORUM

Srijon Chowdhury

Sebastian Zinn, October, 2022



Srijon Chowdhury, *Mouth (Divine Dance)*, 2022, oil on linen, five panels, 6' × 10' 6" each, 6' × 52' 6" overall.

Srijon Chowdhury's debut solo museum exhibition metes out dizzying variations in style, genre, and scale. Yet his work's coherence around the themes of life, death, and myth anchors the viewer.

Visitors are greeted by *Pale Rider,* 2019, a large-scale painting of an alabaster horse and its scythe-carrying passenger. The ground this reaper traverses pullulates with floral motifs rendered with varying degrees of verisimilitude—some resemble sea stars or star fruit more than blossoms. This otherworldly garden is bounded by a metallic-looking fence shaped to resemble text, which sprouts from the canvas's base, and a crepuscular horizon inches from its top edge. Like much of Chowdhury's work, *Pale Rider* is laced with allusions. The letter fence is composed from a distorted line out of a William Blake poem, while the image recalls the flat, tapestry-like works of Klimt's "Golden Period" and horsemen portrayed by Rembrandt, Kandinsky, or even Clint Eastwood.

This sprawling, surreal picture is juxtaposed with concise feats of hyperrealism, as we see in other works such as *Inez with Sunflowers,* 2022, in which a moody child contemplates a fading bouquet. The titular arrangement of blooms is positioned on a table directly between us, so that the child's upward gaze mirrors our own.

The crescendo of "Same Old Song"—the title of Chowdhury's exhibition here—is a large gallery containing six monumental close-ups of two human eyes, a pair of ears, a nose, and a mouth. Each piece features a different tableau: A climactic water birth is emblazoned across an iris in *Eye (Birth)*, while a figure resembling Saint George issues from the eponymous subject of *Ear (Good)*, both 2022. On the lips that gird the hellish, fifty-two-foot-wide maw in *Mouth (Divine Dance)*, 2022, one deciphers shadowy figures excerpted from Chowdhury's other paintings. Doubles of both the pallid rider and the woman in labor are faintly visible.

Suspended across the gallery's four walls, these images bring eye, ears, nose, and mouth together into a single psyche—one witness to a world teeming with martyrs, flowers, and demons.

P·P·O·W

VARIABLE WEST

Srijon Chowdhury's 'Groundhog Day' at SE Cooper Contemporary

Hannah Krafcik, April 7, 2022



Srijon Chowdhury, *Dean*, 2022. Oil on Linen. 24 x 36 inches. Courtesy of SE Cooper Contemporary.

Srijon Chowdhury's exhibition, Groundhog Day, is a lesson in subtle cues. Twelve paintings line the windowed walls of SE Cooper Contemporary, depicting an enigmatic array of subjects, interspersed with views into the wooded Portland suburbs. Beyond the gallery's entrance, a conspicuous gate gives the exhibition a kind of gravity.

Apparition and otherworldliness manifest in subtle ways across many pieces of the exhibition—though Chowdhury's human subjects appear distracted or removed from this influence. Upon closer inspection, their demeanor seems to suggest metaphysical unrest. Their facial expressions read like opaque portals into these hidden realms of disquiet, where questions of the human condition run rampant.

After walking through the front door of the gallery, *Dean* (2022) is the first to greet me. The human subject of this work sits on a leather couch, absently holding a book. They appear physically comfortable but psychologically malcontent, as if something is amiss. Their solitude gestures toward a moment of social isolation during the COVID-19 pandemic.

I look further into the painting: fruit sits on a table, alive and luscious. Light pours in from windows to the outside world, but the subject faces away from it, their eyes distant, indicating an already preoccupied mind, tending to its own machinations. Herein lies a theme, consistent throughout the exhibition: an absent gaze that denies knowability.



On the left: Srijon Chowdhury, *Cruelty Has a Human Heart And Jealousy a Human Face*, 2022. Welded Steel. 55 x 90 inches. Courtesy of SE Cooper Contemporary; on the right: Terror The Human Form Divine And Secrecy, The Human Dress, 2022. Welded Steel. 55 x 90 inches. Courtesy of SE Cooper Contemporary.

As I move further into the exhibition, historical conceptions of human fallibility disrupt my categorization of Chowdhury's work as pandemic art. In order to pass into the second room of the gallery, I cross a threshold where two large gate panels are installed on either side, creating a passageway. Their spires nearly touch the ceiling, and they bear lettering of different sizes, communicating a message I cannot interpret. The gallery owner, Derek Franklin, told me the gate panels contain a stanza from "A Divine Image," a 1789 poem by William Blake from his *Songs of Experience*, which reads:

"Cruelty has a Human Heart

And Jealousy a Human Face

Terror the Human Form Divine

And Secrecy, the Human Dress"

Blake's text conjures the Judeo-Christian belief that humanity suffers from moral depravity, providing an ancient, meditative pretext for the pieces in the following room.



Srijon Chowdhury, *Broc*, 2021. Oil on Linen. 24 x 18 inches. Courtesy of SE Cooper Contemporary.

The direct gaze of Broc (2021) catches my attention, beyond the gates. At first look, the sallow, bed-ridden subject seems to be suffering from an illness. Their pale skin sinks in around their eyes, the veins in their forearm, and their ribcage. But within their dark stare, I discover rich depths that belie a lively inner life—perhaps they are not unwell after all, I wonder. Their unrelenting eye contact typifies the powers of social masking, as it both obscures the person's inner life and tempts me to speculate about it. The slightest grin slides across their lips, as if to say, "you cannot know what I am thinking about."

To the left of this confounding character hangs Anna Recovering (2021). I assess the subject as a doctor might—"no acute distress, well-appearing, eurythmic"—for they look lovely and composed, meeting the moment with a formidable tenor and brave countenance. Gentle light seeps through a backdrop of glowing curtains behind them, accenting their pursed lips and averted gaze. I cannot help but wonder if this person is truly as put together as they appear, or if they have learned to hide their interior world to the same extent I have. I recognize their stalwart mask as one I find myself wearing to hide internal waves of upset. This social dress of secrecy is rarely intentional.



Srijon Chowdhury, *Lilli*, 2022. Oil on Linen. 12 x 16 inches. Courtesy of SE Cooper Contemporary.

Chowdhury also employs imagery of red and pink flowers in many works, several of which radiate with a supernatural luster that indicate their otherworldly nature. In *Lili* (2022), a person holds a luminous red rose up to their pale face, looking lost in a memory conjured by its scent. In *Glowing Roses for Oda* (2021), a duo of flowers gleam among an array of blood-red plant life, like two beacons calling to me from an alternate universe, where undefined possibilities bloom.



Srijon Chowdhury, *My Good Ear*, 2022. Oil on Linen. 30 x 20 inches. Courtesy of SE Cooper Contemporary.

In *My Good Ear* (2022), Chowdhury recreates the tumult of Luca Giordano's Baroque painting, *St. Michael* (1663), bringing otherworldly characters to the fore within a close-up of his own ear. Amidst the fleshy folds of cartilage, an angel crushes and stabs a desperate figure, who cries into Chowdhury's ear canal, its mouth agape. It makes me wonder if secret sagas like this are also unfolding for Chowdhury's other subjects. Is this what they are all so distracted by? And, if so, will they heed these cries of discordance?

The archetypal saga that plays out in Chowdhury's ear reminds me of my own experiences of debilitating overstimulation—moments when I am overcome to the point that every mundane interaction feels beyond my control and full of infinite complexity that I cannot ignore.

This specter of personal agitation rises to the surface of "Groundhog Day," implying that emotional confusion and even spiritual dilemmas abound for Chowdhury's subjects. At the exhibition's center, Blake's poem foregrounds the murkiness of the human condition and imposes its moralism. Indeed, humanity at large is saddled with the impossible task of existing in bodies that cannot fathom the full extent of their beingness, much less manage to understand or do right by one another. But Chowdhury reframes these mysteries as tantalizing, even in their uncertainty. The people in his work remain haunted by unknown thoughts and apparitions that entice me to explore their hidden nature—no matter how beautiful or terrible it turns out to be.

P·P·O·W

THE NEW YORKER

Goings on About Town

Johanna Fateman, April 24, 2020



Srijon Chowdhury at Foxy Production, New York, 2020

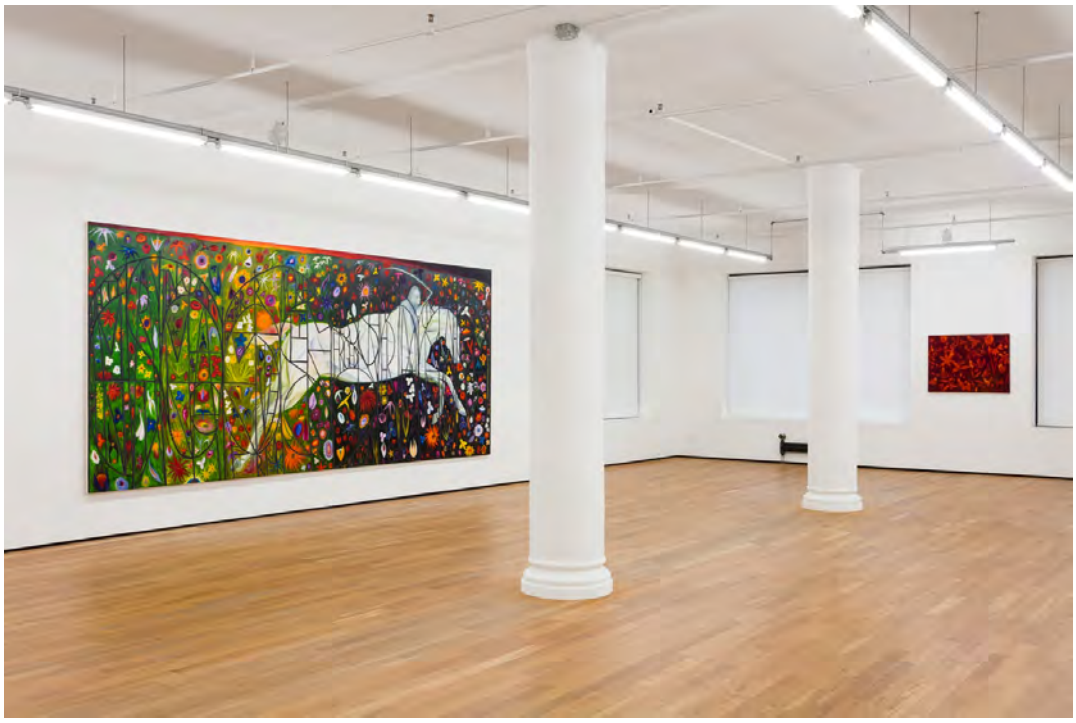
Srijon Chowdhury

In Chowdhury's eerily beautiful world, the mythic and the contemporary merge. The Bangladeshi painter, who now divides his time between Portland, Oregon, and L.A., channels the macabre effervescence of Odilon Redon in the centerpiece of his New York début, at Foxy Production (viewable on the gallery's Web site). Titled "Pale Rider," the canvas recasts the fourth Horseman of the Apocalypse as a woman on a spectral mount; the incongruous backdrop of vibrant wildflowers behind a lattice of text takes some cues from the Viennese Secessionists. (Size doesn't translate onscreen, but it's worth noting that the picture is sixteen feet long.) Other paintings, including a still-life of clementines, a nighttime view of Notre Dame, and portraits—of a father and child, a female Narcissus in jeans, and a Christlike male nude holding a glowing rose—seductively blur gender roles and art-historical lexicons.

Editorial

Srijon Chowdhury at Foxy Production

Rebecca Storm, April 7, 2020



“Cruelty has a Human Heart,” reads the first line of William Blake’s, A Divine Image. The poem, originally published in 1789, is unsurprisingly still poignant today, and in its entirety appears almost super-imposed over an ethereal white horse and its passenger in Srijon Chowdhury’s expansive painting, Pale Rider. Featured in an eponymous solo exhibition at Foxy Production in New York City, Chowdhury’s works reinterpret traditional approaches to painting by subverting genre, medium, and mythology. Two clementines by a glass, one moldy and one fresh, suggest a plutonian motif of death and birth, while also serving to reference the practice of vanitas image- making. This dichotomy is echoed again in Flowers on Fire, featuring the endangered trillium and ubiquitous morning glory blooms, all ablaze in a neon cadmium—fire does not hierarchize. The same brilliant red lends itself to a rose, cupped in two hands, or suspended above a boy lying down. An Old Dream features a bouquet of roses, dried and anemic next to scissors in a milky dusk, illuminated only by a slit of the same lustrous red—a somatic proposal that perhaps there is life on the other side. If we cut away this darkness, will we find new life?

P·P·O·W

artnet

Editors' Picks: 8 Things Not to Miss in the Virtual Art World This Week

Sarah Cascone, March 16, 2020

Each week, we search New York City for the most exciting, and thought-provoking, shows, screenings, and events. This week, in light of the global health crisis, we are highlighting events and exhibitions available digitally. See our picks from around the world below.



Srijon Chowdhury, Pale Rider, 2019. Courtesy of Foxy Production.

6. "Srijon Chowdhury" at Foxy Production

Srijon Chowdhury's first solo show in New York opened at Foxy Production during Armory Week, and despite the closures of galleries across the city, it was enough of a highlight that it's worth catching it on the gallery website. Born in Dhaka, Bangladesh, Chowdhury's saturated paintings of flowers are often framed with botanical or architectural elements. The result resembles religious tableaus or prayer cards, while the intensity in which Chowdhury applies color gives the canvas an almost fluorescent look. "Color affects a person viscerally and quickly," the artist has said. "I think about the chakras which begins with crimson that roots us to this reality and this body." Also included in the exhibition are portraits and scenes from parenthood and an enormous 16-foot-wide oil painting titled *Pale Rider*.

Time: 24/7

—*Cristina Cruz*

Through Sunday, April 26

P·P·O·W

ARTFORUM

Srijon Chowdhury

Daniel Gerwin, October 14, 2019

Anat Ebgi | Culver City
2660 S La Cienega Blvd.
November 2, 2019 - December 14, 2019



Srijon Chowdhury, *Red Morning Glory, Red Knife*, 2019, oil on linen, 24 x 18".

Life and death spiral around each other in “A Divine Dance,” Srijon Chowdhury’s first exhibition at Anat Ebgi. Two sober, modestly scaled paintings represent life with particular frankness: *Birth* (all works 2019) documents Chowdhury’s child emerging from his girlfriend’s straining body, while in the dark and tender *3am*, close inspection reveals a hand holding a bottle to an infant’s mouth. Similar subjects are given a different treatment elsewhere, as in *A Divine Dance*, which towers more than eleven feet high. Its physical edges are doubled by two hands whose elongated fingers meet at the top to suggest a fleshy portal, within which Chowdhury’s pregnant girlfriend carries a Christ-like baby through flames, demons, and flowers, all depicted in swirls of crimson. The image veers into melodrama, a tone the young artist approaches but does not enter in his best work.

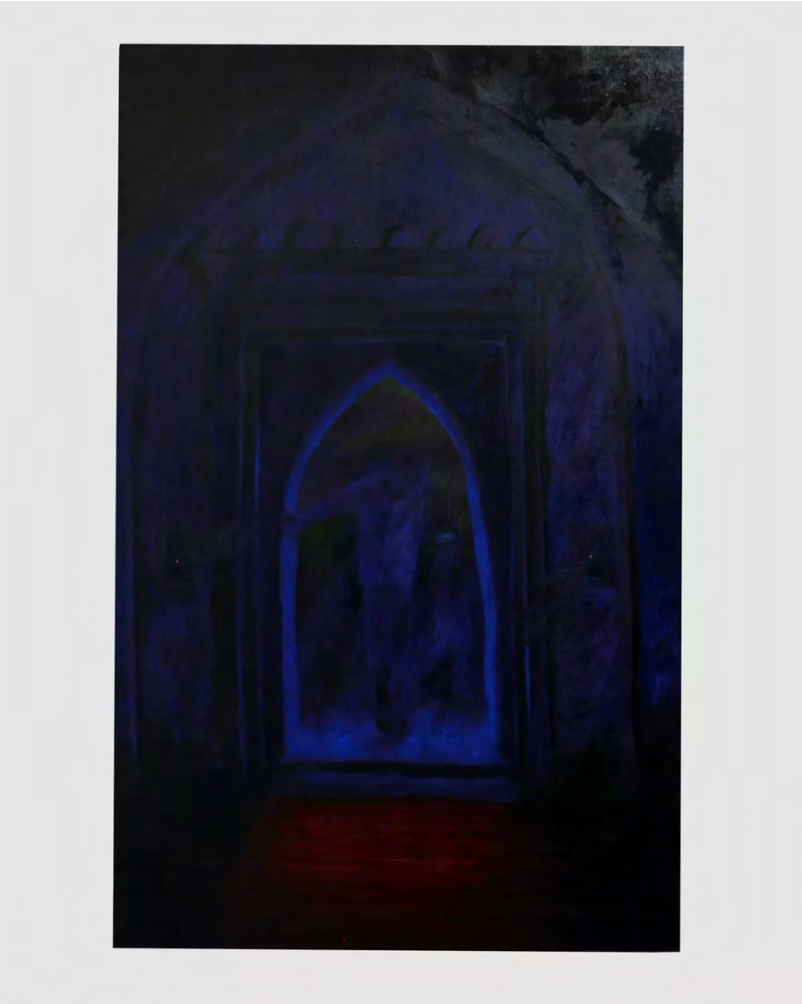
Death gets its due in several paintings, including *Red Morning Glory, Red Knife*, in which the green of a thorny vine balances the titular reds. A left hand cradles a morning glory—a flower that blooms and withers the same day—while the right hand holds a sanguineous blade to the flower's stem. *Pale Rider* is sixteen feet wide, full of beauty and free of bombast: An alabaster woman straddling a white horse holds a scythe as the animal gallops through a riotous profusion of flowers. All this is seen through a layer of text from William Blake's poem "A Divine Image," published in the late 1700s. Rendered as a thin metal lattice, the words run from the left edge of the canvas all the way to the right. Chowdhury's exhibition as a whole is not pitch-perfect, but this painting is.

P·P·O·W

Los Angeles Times

Review: Srijon Chowdhury paintings pull you in for a closer look

Sharon Mizota, September 16, 2016



Srijon Chowdhury's "Dad entering my great great grandfather Asgar's mosque," 2016. (Daphne Mangin / Klowden Mann)

Srijon Chowdhury's paintings at Klowden Mann are hard to see. At first glance, they look like deep blue monochromes. On closer inspection, details emerge: folds of cloth, a hand, the glow of a cellphone screen.

With slightly more effort, you can discern murky figures caught in banal but solitary moments: smoking, talking on the phone, just hanging out. These images are somewhat fugitive, submerged in blue shadows and entombed in flickering layers of varnish that render them fleeting at best.

In this, Chowdhury's work invokes the Impressionists, who recorded scenes of bourgeois life in optically dazzling scrims of paint. It also, oddly, reminds me of looking at an Ad Reinhardt black painting, whose subtle shifts in tone evoke a searching, fathomless feeling that makes me aware of my own desire to see.

These are lofty comparisons for paintings of what are essentially casual snapshots, but the charm of Chowdhury's work is that it imbues mundane scenes with a romantic, almost religious awe. The only painting that strays from bars, cafes and domestic scenes drives this association home. "Dad entering my great great grandfather Asgar's mosque" depicts the shadowy figure of a man framed within a pointed arch delineated with an ethereal glow. Like his father in this image, Chowdhury's paintings occupy a threshold between the visible and something more mysterious.



Srijon Chowdhury's "Anna drying her hair on the towels hanging from our bedroom door," 2016. (Mario Gallucci / Klowden Mann)



Srijon Chowdhury's "Making a painting," 2016. (Daphne Margin / Klowden Mann)

P·P·O·W

OREGON ARTSWATCH
ARTS & CULTURE NEWS
orartswatch.org

Srijon Chowdhury: Remembering memory

Nim Wunnan, May 20, 2016



Srijon Chowdhury, Memory Theater, Upfor / Photo courtesy of Mario Gallucci and Upfor Gallery

This is a pretty rich vein of historical material to mine if you're building an installation. With some forceful labeling and maybe an essay or two, a lot of artists could get away with referencing the concept as an inspiration and throwing up what they choose. However, painter Srijon Chowdhury seems to have fully apprehended how the conceptual structure of Camillo's *Memory Theater* fits into the contemporary gallery experience.

The architecture of Chowdhury's *Memory Theater* consists of a semicircle of tall panels of thin, translucent linen stretched over wooden frames, very close to being workable canvases. However, the backs of these panels are fitted with cardboard ribs to form cells and arches within the main frames. The arch is one of Chowdhury's major painting motifs: He has often shown his large, dreamlike canvases arranged on the floor or walls as if they were actual portals that could be stepped through, placing them as if they were doors or part of an archway. Here, the form has escaped from his canvases to manifest in the real space of the gallery in a variety of ways. *Memory Theater* feels like a crystallization of his images of verdant and enticing, yet distant spaces and the motif of archways and foliage, gathered solidly on the framework of Camillo's imagined temple of memory.

Sculptures, objects, and images from 28 artists fill the segments in the back of the panels and line the floor on the theater's outside perimeter. The gallery windows are fully blacked out, and the room is lit with simple spotlights colored by purplish, red, and blue theater gels. Even a quick glance through Chowdhury's back catalogue of paintings will make it clear how much like the interior of one of his paintings he has made the room. The spotlights project layers of shadows and silhouettes onto the linen of the panels, but the layout

has enough sprawl that you can savor the backstage view as you walk around to the entrance of the theater. A representative at Upfor told me that throughout the exhibition, Chowdhury has been adjusting, adding to, and subtracting from the menagerie of objects during the run of the exhibition, sometimes surreptitiously.



Srijon Chowdhury, *Memory Theater*, Upfor / Photo courtesy of Mario Gallucci and Upfor Gallery

Almost all the work was made independent of this exhibition and chosen or requested by Chowdhury from friends and colleagues (hence his credit as "director" rather than "curator"). The selection makes it quite clear that he splits his time between Portland and LA. The purple-redness of the whole thing reads almost like someone mixed Pacific Northwest skies into the typically bright pastels of the newly-dominant LA contemporary look, but there is a recognizable aesthetic to many of the sculptures. I, and most people who have been to a gallery or an art fair in LA recently, have seen a lot of charmingly-wiggly, wrong-in-all-the-right-ways ceramics and distressingly bodily objects of no discernible use that *seem* to want to be used for some obscure purpose. I'm not dinging them for being one of the looks of the moment, but there was something intensely satisfying about seeing them put to work in the structure of *Memory Theater*.

Underlying this aesthetic and the recent manifestation of religion-less ritual and spirituality in art spaces, I think there's something that fits very well with Camillo's ultimately-impossible dream. His Memory Theater combines the canonical hubris of attempts to capture all useful knowledge (like Munster's *Cosmographia*) with the ritualistic storytelling of stained-glass windows (where you literally paint a story onto the boundaries of the space where it should be learned). We have ubiquitous access to vast stores of data and knowledge that Camillo couldn't have imagined, but this has shattered any illusion of ever having a useful and complete knowledge about the world around us. The Internet has stripped away many layers of mystery that used to take years to peer through, but it has ultimately brought us closer to Borges' library than Camillo's Memory Theater.



Katie Thoma, *Storage 2*, 2016 casters, wood; 26 x 26 x 26 inches; *Storage 1*, 2016. tile, wood, packaging material; 20 x 20 x 20 inches, in Srijon Chowdhury's Memory Theater, Upfor / Photo courtesy of Mario Gallucci and Upfor Gallery

The sort of ritualistic, alchemical ways of gathering evidence and creating knowledge about the world that Camillo worked with were essentially a way to make a comfortable, observably consistent system out of a complex world that hid its underlying principles from us. No wonder Camillo warned us to be esoteric about deep knowledge—what options did you have without modern statistics, particle colliders, and computer modeling?

Likewise, the shifting, decentered art world can't be apprehended with a hard grip of a Unified Theory or a new, new-ism. It makes sense that this environment would produce the peculiar objects Chowdhury has chosen as actors in his theater. They feel like implements from a lumpier, neighboring universe that we will never learn to use correctly, but this gives us the space to make the connections and inferences that we choose.

When you sit in the center of the theater, you only see their shadows on the fabric, which pushes any "hard meaning" of the objects further from you yet gives you more power to imagine. Painting has been immune to its many obituaries because of how well it teaches the ability to wield ambiguity in this way. It teaches how to give the viewer entrance to a strange land, and how to lay enough of a trail for them to find things, but not so much that they don't feel like they are making their own discoveries. You have a week left to go sit in the *Memory Theater* and make some discoveries of your own.

Make a point of spending some time with Chowdhury's paintings, which are unfortunately hung in awkward locations, seemingly as compromises to space and lighting. Also be on the lookout for little, obscene drawings of naked figures scattered throughout the artifacts and plants in the theater. They're one of the only purpose-made contributions, referencing the practice of using shocking or suggestive imagery to fix memories in place.

P·P·O·W

art ltd.

Artist Profile: Srijon Chowdhury

Richard Speer, May/June, 2016



It's hard to imagine two studios more dissimilar than the ones Srijon Chowdhury pivots be- tween in Los Angeles and Port- land, Oregon. In the bustle and din of the Jefferson Park neighborhood of LA, blocks from Koreatown, he shares with two other artists a dark, cave- like space with barred windows and leaky pipes; while in the sylvan hills of southeast Portland, he has his own studio, airy, open, and quiet, save for the chirping of birds outside and the rustling of breezes through evergreens. The artist has been dividing his time between Southern California and the Pacific Northwest for two years now, and while negotiating such disparate milieux might prove whiplash inducing for some artists, it comes naturally to Chowdhury, who's spent a lifetime moving fluidly between cultures. Born 29 years ago in Dhaka to a Bangladeshi father and an American mother, he traveled frequently between Bangladesh and the US as a youth. Today, his artwork often integrates motifs from the artistic, architectural, and spiritual traditions of the two countries. Case in point: his current exhibition, "Memory Theater," at Portland's UPFOR Gallery, which runs through May—a circular installation that viewers are encouraged to meditate inside. The work is based on a set of arches at a mosque near Chittagong, Bangladesh, which the artist visited many times, most recently in February 2015. Reinterpreting those arches with stretcher bars and linen, he created a network of 11 panels, with light flooding in to impart a honeyed, opaque glow. He sees the space's interior as a contemplative zone akin to Monet's Nymphéas, a wrap-around environment of water-lily paintings at the

Musée de l'Orangerie in Paris: "the colors and the softness of it, the way the shadows hit the linen and bleed into it with this feathered quality..." Hanging from and leaning onto the structure's exterior will be works by two-dozen artists from the US, Columbia, Iceland, and Norway. Those artists, Chowdhury explains, share a common thematic focus on "work that's ritualistic, fetishistic, or outside of time."

The exhibition's title refers to the idea of a "memory theater" advanced by Giulio Camillo, an Italian Renaissance thinker who proposed an invention that would serve as a repository of knowledge. People could access this knowledge simply by walking through a three-dimensional structure filled with objects. "I'm thinking of [the show] as a theater piece, a spectacle," Chowdhury says. "The gallery becomes a theater, the painting becomes a stage, and the viewer is an actor activating the work." The installation incorporates a sound component composed by his friend and collaborator, Brian Strandberg. The soundtrack's rhythm derives from the sound waves generated by a black hole—a nod to the artist's interest in science and science fiction. Combining such eclectic influences—Islamic architecture, Renaissance thought, sci-fi—into one installation is a typically inclusive strategy for this artist, who grew up surrounded by art from around the world (his parents were gallery owners and avid collectors). During his undergraduate studies at the University of Minnesota, he studied journalism as well as art, which infused his aesthetic viewpoint with a broad, multidisciplinary range. After graduating, he traveled to Mexico and Norway before returning to the academy and earning an MFA from Otis College of Art and Design in Los Angeles. While he is primarily a painter—and one deeply interested in painterly effects—he is equally committed to exploring the ways in which paintings are viewed and the meta-functions they fulfill. Although many of his paintings incorporate the figure, he is quick to point out that these figures are metaphorical, not parts of a traditional narrative.

So far this year, Chowdhury has been pressing forward his interdisciplinary investigations on a range of fronts. In addition to "Memory Theater" at UPFOR, Chowdhury will have work in a group show in May at Vox Populi, an artist run nonprofit gallery in Philadelphia, and in September he will have a solo show at Klowden Mann Gallery in Los Angeles. For that show, he's preparing a suite of blue-hued figurative paintings in which the colors grade so liminally, the figures appear to dematerialize.

When it comes to discussing his intent, Chowdhury is earnest, thoughtful, and resolutely unswayed by the art world's orientation toward irony and post-irony. He believes art can and should change lives, including his own. "A lot of my work the last few years," he reflects, "has been about origin stories—trying to get back to the beginning in the hopes of making the world better. I've been trying to understand who we are and what it means to be human, which is something that's always changing. What comes from that figuring-out process is an enlightenment that I'm after, a moving forward. I want to learn from making this work. I want it to affect what I think and do."



"Memory Theater," installation view Photo: Mario Gallucci. Courtesy: UPFOR Gallery